into which we led ourselves. Our forces could not have stopped the Chinese at the Nam Ka Chu or at the Chip Chap or at Walong and should never have been sent there for that purpose. But the fact remains that at all these places the army did its best and made the Chinese pay a price for their gains. Only at Se-la have we betrayed our trust. There, where we could have stopped them, we ran away without fighting—and the tragedy is that the betrayal came not from the troops but from the generals in command.

'You asked me for a frank opinion. I think that all three generals—Pathania, Kaul and Sen—would be deemed remiss in battle; but you were also there. You elected to be present at Corps HQ—and you did not succeed in preventing Pathania's defection. So my answer is "Yes". I think it's appropriate that you should accept the responsibility for the disaster at Se-la. If I were you, I would go straight to the Prime Minister when we arrive at Delhi, explain frankly what happened and why, and offer my resignation. I hope that he will not accept it; but as the Chief you have to take all the blame on your shoulders.'

Palit felt that his advice notwithstanding, Thapar had already made up his mind by then. By all accounts, Thapar was an upright and conscientious officer, but a lacklustre personality who did not have the combat experience of Thimayya, Thorat or even Sen for that matter. No one, perhaps Thapar included, had expected him to be elevated to the top post.

Now it was almost as if the wheel had turned a full circle. After going over Palit's recast notes for the defence of Assam, Thapar asked his DMO who in his opinion should succeed him: 'Muchhu' Chaudhuri, the then Southern Army Commander, or General Thorat, who had retired?

In his list of general officers who he felt needed to shoulder the blame, Palit was aware that there was another name that needed to be added—his own. Even though he was a brigadier, he was the DMO and the most important cog in the operational chain that was controlled by Army HQ. Palit was also acutely aware of the circumstances under which Thapar and Kaul had emerged as the front runners by sidelining Thimayya and Thorat. As CGS, Kaul had hand-picked Palit for the DMO's job, and what was more, Palit had initially been fairly critical of Thorat's defensive line, even though he had subsequently seen its merits. Palit admits that he made a big blunder at the time. He would write later: 'I fear that mindlessly I gave him the wrong answer. Perhaps because I did not know Thorat well, I replied that I did not consider it advisable to bring back a retired general officer as